Narrative Structure

Narrative

Narrative Structure

Movies use a narrative structure that is very similar to the way that events are organized by novelists, short-story writers, playwrights, comedians, and other storytellers. In all these cases, the basic formula that has evolved is calculated to engage and satisfy the receiver of the story.

The use of the word *formula* can be misleading. Most stories may follow the same general progression, but narrative is not a single simple recipe. In order to organize story events into a recognizable progression, some screenwriters break the narrative into three acts, or sections; others prefer to divide the action into five acts; others—particularly television writers—employ a seven-act structure. Not that it really matters to the audience. Our experience of the story as a continuous sequence of events is not affected by any particular screenwriter's organizational approach to partitioning the narrative development.

Most narratives can be broken into three basic pieces that essentially function as the beginning, middle, and end of the story. Each section performs a fundamental narrative task. The first act sets up the story; the second (and longest) act develops it; the third act resolves it. Of course, nothing as expressive and engaging as cinematic storytelling can be quite *that* simple. Each of these narrative components involves a few moving parts.

The Normal World

The setup in the first act has to tell us what kind of a story we're about to experience by establishing the **normal world**. A movie's first few minutes lay out the rules of the universe that we will inhabit (or at least witness) for the next couple of hours. Our expectations of the story also depend on learning the movie's tone. Character, which we already know to be the linchpin of the story, must also be established. The narrative often begins by revealing something about the protagonist's current situation, often by showing him engaged in an action that also reveals some of those essential character traits we discussed earlier in the chapter.

For example, in the Coen brothers' *The Big Lebowski* (1998), we first meet Jeff Lebowski—known to his friends as The Dude—as he shuffles into a supermarket dairy section dressed in sunglasses, pajama shorts, flip-flops, and a well-worn bathrobe. The Dude scrutinizes the assortment like a connoisseur in a wine cellar, then cracks open a carton of half and half to sniff the contents. In the next shot, he pays for his selection with a check for 69 cents.

Before we even learn his name, we know that The Dude is a free spirit who plays by his own rules. He's a slob, is not necessarily smart, and is certainly not ambitious—but he does have standards. Thus we already have some of the essential information we'll need to anticipate and appreciate his particular response to the events and situations the narrative is about to present. We have been initiated into the story's comic, absurdist tone and are also becoming acquainted with the movie's normal world: Jeff Lebowski inhabits a decidedly unglamorous Los Angeles sprawl of dilapidated bungalows, strip malls, and bowling alleys.

***The Big Lebowski* (Joel Coen and Ethan Coen, 1998)**

Once the character and their world have been established, it's time to get the story started. For this to happen, something must occur to change that normal world. The inciting incident (also known as the **catalyst**) presents the character with the goal that will drive the rest of the narrative.

Screenwriting specialist Syd Field describes "plot points" as significant events that turn the narrative in a new direction. For example, the development of *The Grand Budapest Hotel* (2014; director Wes Anderson) is profoundly influenced by the death of Madame D. The plot point leads to her convoluted last will and testament being contested by her greedy heirs,

her lover Gustave stealing the priceless painting he believes is rightfully his, and a high-stakes search for the butler accused of her murder.

***The Grand Budapest Hotel* (Wes Anderson, 2014)**

Likewise, the moment when Agatha discovers Madame D.'s rightful will hidden in the stolen painting certainly qualifies as a plot point. Gustave inherits her vast fortune, buys the Grand Budapest Hotel, and promotes his faithful protégé Zero to head concierge.

***The Grand Budapest Hotel* (Wes Anderson, 2014)**

Obstacles

Narrative depends on obstacles to block, or at least impede, our protagonist's quest for the goal. The person, people, creature, or force responsible for obstructing our protagonist is known as the antagonist.

Whatever the source, obstacles are the second act's key ingredient. In the opening scene of Danny Boyle's *127 Hours* (2010), the way the protagonist Aron Ralston (James Franco) packs establishes that he is a loner and an experienced, if overconfident, outdoorsman. As he scrambles around his spartan apartment throwing climbing gear and provisions into a day bag, he doesn't bother to locate his missing Swiss Army knife and ignores a call from his sister. Now that the narration has conveyed some of Aron's flaws, he has some room to grow, and we're prepared to chart and appreciate his development as the adventure unfolds.

Aron ventures into the desert wilds of the remote Canyonlands National Park. Along the way, he reaffirms his character traits by luring two novice hikers to an exhilarating but dangerous plunge into an underground pool before leaving them behind to trek still deeper into the wilderness. In the process of descending a deep slot canyon, Aron dislodges a small boulder. The man and the rock both tumble down the narrow ravine. When they meet again at the bottom, the rock pins Aron's forearm to the canyon wall. This sudden event gives our protagonist a goal, supplies the story with conflict and an antagonist, and begins the second act.

The next hour of the movie is devoted to Aron's struggle to free himself. That struggle can be broken down into the series of obstacles he encounters. Aron will overcome some of them, circumvent others, and surrender to still more. Obviously, his tightly wedged forearm is Aron's greatest obstacle. He attempts to yank it loose, he uses his cheap multi-tool to try to chip away at the rock, and he builds a pulley system with his climbing ropes. Nothing works.

***127 Hours* (Danny Boyle, 2010)**

Before the Aron Ralston character can finally achieve his narrative goal, he must first engage a series of obstacles. He tries (almost) every possible method of freeing his forearm from the stubborn rock pinning it to a remote canyon wall, insulates himself from freezing temperatures with his otherwise useless climbing rope, and retrieves his dropped multi-tool with his toes. The crisis comes when Aron must take dramatic action or die.

Narrative Obstacles in *127 Hours*

Narrative Structure Schematic

The deeper we get into the story, the greater the risk to our protagonist. What begins as a possibility of getting lost progresses to the dangers of being trapped, which develops into what appears to be certain death. Of course, the ultimate magnitude of the stakes depends on the movie.

The **stakes** are rising because the obstacles are becoming increasingly difficult for our protagonist to navigate. Over the course of the second act, narrative typically builds toward a peak, a breaking point of sorts, as the conflict intensifies and the goal remains out of reach. This **rising action** is illustrated in the figure below. The tension it provokes enhances our engagement with the ongoing narrative.

Eventually, our protagonist must face a seemingly insurmountable obstacle, and our story must reach a turning point and work its way toward resolution and the third and final act. This narrative peak is called the **crisis**. The goal is in its greatest jeopardy, and an affirmative answer to the central question seems all but impossible.

The **climax** comes when the protagonist faces this major obstacle. In the process, usually the protagonist must take a great risk, make a significant sacrifice, or overcome a personal flaw. As the term implies, the climax tends to be the most impressive event in the movie.

Once the goal is either gained or lost, it's time for the resolution—the third act of falling action, in which the narrative wraps up loose ends and moves toward a conclusion.

Figure 4.1 | NARRATIVE STRUCTURE SCHEMATIC

Narrative structure is typically characterized by a three-act format. The first act establishes character, setting, and tone, then introduces a goal with an inciting incident. The second act is structured around the protagonist's pursuit of the goal and the conflict and obstacles that must be confronted before the goal is either gained or lost at the peak of the rising action and stakes. The narrative then falls as the third act resolves the conflict, wraps up ongoing story lines, and gives the viewer a chance to either celebrate or mourn the dramatic result. Diagrams like this are helpful in visualizing a standard structure, but we should keep in mind that the shape any story takes is as flexible as the filmmakers want it to be.

Narrative Structure in *1917*

Once the goal is either gained or lost, it's time for the **resolution**—the third act of falling action, in which the narrative wraps up loose ends and moves toward a conclusion. For some protagonists, the struggle continues well into this final act. After being trapped for 127 hours and amputating his own arm, Aron must still strike out in search of help.

Not all protagonists achieve their goal, because not all stories are meant to have a happy ending. In *Queen & Slim* (2019; director Melina Matsoukas), the protagonists are Black, the inciting incident is a racially motivated traffic stop that results in the death of the police officer, the goal is to escape capture (and the country), and the obstacles are products of a society unwilling to consider the facts surrounding the officer's death. The final obstacle confronted in the crisis is indeed insurmountable; both protagonists are killed before they can board a plane to freedom.

***Queen & Slim* (Melina Matsoukas, 2019)**